a career in accounting – now *that* would've been interesting – but during my school days, rugby and football were the front-runners.

I played provincial schoolboy rugby, representing Western Province at Craven Week, and then later I played for the Villagers Second XV and Western Province's Under-21s. Former Springbok flyhalf and rugby legend Naas Botha even came up to me during my last Craven Week match and said, 'Ja, you'll be the next Springbok flyhalf.'

Things were looking really promising in that direction, and becoming a professional rugby player was tempting … But that wasn't what I *really* wanted. Football was the game I loved the most and, to be honest, the sport in which I knew I had the most talent. I had people tell me – and these are guys who have gone on to play professional football in Europe – that when they played with me as youngsters, I was streets ahead of them.

I wouldn't say I was a football genius, but I really think I could have gone a long way in the sport. Unfortunately, any dreams I had of running out for my beloved Manchester United were ended by a knee injury sustained while playing rugby when I was 20. The doc I was seeing gave me some very good advice. He said, 'You can play cricket a lot longer than rugby or football. Just give up rugby and football, and concentrate on your cricket.'

It was wise counsel, and even though it was hard for me to hear it, as I'd already got so far in my rugby, the truth of the matter was that I just didn't really have the build to play another 10 years of rugby. Cricket, on the other hand, offered the chance of having a long-term career. Of course I loved the game, but up until then it was just the sport I played in summer. I hadn't ever thought of cricket as a potential career.

Studying further was obviously out of the question. As I mentioned, my academic record was less than stellar, and even my parents understood – and my dad was even a teacher, remember – that I best put those reflexes and coordination to work earning money, because it sure as hell wasn't going to happen I if went to college or varsity.

I knew there was a chance that I could go places with sport. I knew I had the talent to play professional football, rugby or cricket, but when the first two were no longer an option, it necessarily had to be cricket.

Fortunately, looking back now over a career that has so far spanned 20-odd years as a professional, the decision I made was the right one. I've made the most of my longevity. Whereas for a long time the rugby players